

Tips For Defragmenting

- ❑ Do not open any files when the defragmenter is running, else the process will start all over again!
- ❑ Turn off anti-virus programs during defragmenting as background scanning may come in way of the defragmenter.
- ❑ Defragmenter works best with more free space at hand for temporary storage. If you have less than 15 per cent free space, the Defragmenter will warn you. You can clear temporary internet files or move data temporarily to other partitions to free up some space.
- ❑ If you are using Windows 98 or 98SE, and find the defragmenter restarting all the time and eventually giving up, you can use the defragmenter from Windows ME. Download it from <http://www.the-old-sea-dog.net/defrag/w9x-medefrag.zip>

ing', it can be accessed by right-clicking on the desired drive (or partition), **Properties > Tools > Error Checking**. Windows 98 users can run scandisk by booting into DOS prompt and typing "scandisk <Drive>:" where <Drive> is the drive letter you want to scan. This is more reliable than running scandisk from Windows.

Data Recovery

All of us have, at some time or the other, emptied the Recycle Bin only to realise that some important files got deleted.

There's a way out: you can recover your "deleted" files using data recovery software, provided, of course, that the space the deleted file occupied hasn't been

Using S.M.A.R.T.

Some hard disks have a monitoring and error reporting technology called S.M.A.R.T. (Self Monitoring Analysis and Reporting Technology) that issues a warning during boot-up if certain things are found to be 'wrong' in the hard disk. This is not always reliable, but another step in ensuring that you know when things go wrong. This can be enabled in the BIOS in General or Advanced BIOS settings.

Using Cooling Fan

Heat is a primary cause of electronic component failure. Keeping a device cool goes a long way in extending its life. If your computer is in a hot environment, running applications that use the disk continuously (such as video editing), you can attach a fan to the hard disk. In our test, placing an ordinary case cooling fan such that it blows air onto the hard disk made noticeable difference in the amount of heat that the hard disk reported.

Secure Mounting

If you sense vibrations emanating from the hard disk, just tighten all the screws that are used to fasten it to the chassis (cabinet) in the hard disk bay. Vibrations, though small, can have adverse effects on moving parts through a phenomenon called resonance. Generally two screws on either side are used

to hold the hard disk in place. If necessary, use more screws.

❑ If you are using two or more hard disks, don't simply pile up one above the other—stack them in alternate bays, leaving space for air flow.

Handle With Care

Internal hard disks are less rugged than their external counterparts and need special care while transporting. Put the hard disk in an anti static cover to prevent static electricity from affecting it. Next, to shock proof it, cover it with bubble wrap (if you don't find bubble wrap, you can use cotton cloth, but not synthetic material). Also, make sure you don't drop it!

When you are attaching an IDE cable, ensure that the connector and pins are well aligned and none of the pins on the hard disk are bent. If you see a bent pin, gently straighten it with the help of a flat screw driver or get someone who knows his stuff to do it. Forcing the connector the wrong way or onto bent pins will only create more problems—if a pin gets broken, you will have to take it to a repair shop to fix the broken pin, if at all it can be done.

Backup

The tips we have given you here will reduce the chances of premature failure of your hard disk. However, you cannot neglect the probability of failure due to factors beyond your control. A power surge, for example can destroy the hard disk along with other components. While money can buy you a new hard disk, the same cannot be said about the data that the hard disk contains, especially in a work environment. There is only one definite solution to this risk - backup frequently! ■

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